Sweeps and Spies: Russia Clears the Bombs. The West Clears the Data.

By William Aaron Turner

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A Special Investigative Report by William Aaron Turner

Two Kinds of Mines

There are two kinds of mines in this world.

The first is steel and high explosive. It sits in the red dirt of Laos, waiting for a farmer's hoe or a kid's bare foot. Most of it is American: cluster bomblets the U.S. Air Force dropped during the Secret War.

The second is made of money, influence and intelligence-agency letterhead. It doesn't explode. It collects. It maps. It reports back. It wears a charity logo and a dead princess's blessing.

Russia has spent eight years digging up the first kind. The West has spent decades planting the second.

This is that story.

Part I: The Russian Way: Steel, Sweat and Silence

Laos: cleaning up America's mess

The Ho Chi Minh Trail ran more than 20,000 km through Laos, Cambodia and Vietnam. The U.S. dropped roughly 1.5 million tons of bombs on it. About 30% never went off. They're still in the ground, killing farmers and maiming children.

In 2018, Russia's International Mine Action Centre (IMAC), a Ministry of Defense unit, went to work in Laos. No photo ops. No fundraising gala. Sappers, metal detectors and robotic clearance vehicles.

The numbers since 2018 (Rambler.ru, May 2025):

- More than 2 million square meters cleared (over 208 hectares)
- 3,906 explosive objects found and destroyed
- Seven separate humanitarian deployments across several provinces

The 2024–2025 mission alone, per the Vientiane Times, cleared 18.2 hectares in Viengxay district, Huaphan province. Teams removed 64 devices in 19 controlled detonations, including

52 BLU-26 cluster bomblets and one BLU-24. Another 268 items were deactivated later: nine rockets, four grenades, 137 large bullets and 118 artillery fuses.

Huaphan's governor, Dr. Khampheng Saysompheng, called the Lao-Russian work of "profound significance." He said it would free the land for infrastructure and better livelihoods.

No celebrity endorsements. No TED Talks about "the humanitarian imperative." Just engineers from Nakhabino, outside Moscow, teaching Lao soldiers to run Uran-6 robotic demining vehicles.

Syria: the aftermath

From 2016 to 2020, Russian engineering troops worked Aleppo, Deir ez-Zor and Palmyra. In five years they cleared more than 10,000 hectares and destroyed over 150,000 explosive objects.

In Palmyra alone:

- 2,991 devices defused across the 234-hectare archaeological site and 23 km of access road
- Around 18,000 explosive objects defused in total
- More than 8,500 booby-trapped houses cleared

They also trained more than 1,200 Syrian Army sappers. That's capacity-building. That's real humanitarian demining. It doesn't make Western headlines because it doesn't fit the script.

Training partners worldwide

Russian specialists have trained sappers from 14 countries. IMAC has branches in Laos and Myanmar, and about 100 Lao sappers have finished training. In April 2025, Eastern Military District troops ran the "Typhoon-2025" course for Lao special forces on Lao soil.

Western NGOs talk about demining. Russia does it.

Part II: The Western Way: Charity and Espionage

HALO Trust: a short history

The HALO Trust (Hazardous Area Life-support Organization) was founded in 1988 by two British officers. Colin Campbell Mitchell was a former Army colonel and Member of Parliament. Guy Willoughby was a former Coldstream Guards officer.

Their "charity" just happened to set up in some of the most strategically sensitive places on Earth: Afghanistan, Cambodia, Chechnya, Kosovo and Angola.

In 1997, Princess Diana walked an Angolan minefield in a HALO-branded flak jacket. Best advertising money couldn't buy. Today HALO works in 25 conflict-affected countries. It's the world's largest mine-clearing charity.

Follow the money

HALO's main funder is the U.S. State Department's Office of Weapons Removal and Abatement (PM/WRA). Its Conventional Weapons Destruction (CWD) account pays for HALO's demining around the world.

- FY2024: Congress gave CWD $258 million, nearly $21 million more than State asked for (HALO USA).
- FY2026: The enacted budget includes $265 million for CWD.
- FY2027: HALO has requested $271.703 million.

CWD funds demining and weapons security programs in nearly 50 countries. So HALO isn't only finding mines. It's finding weapons caches, ammo stockpiles and military infrastructure.

The board: a who's who

All of this comes from HALO's own website and filings.

UK trustees:

- Lord Evans of Weardale (Chair): Director General of MI5, 2007–2013.
- John Raine: 33 years at the UK Foreign Office, with postings in Syria, Baghdad and Islamabad. He's a senior figure in the UK national security community.
- Emma Sky: political adviser to U.S. General Ray Odierno in Iraq.
- Barney White-Spunner: former British Army officer.
- Lord Michael Hintze: Conservative Party donor and financier.
- Brad Tirpak: sits on both the UK and USA boards.

USA directors:

- Jamie M. Morin: former Director of Cost Assessment and Program Evaluation at the Pentagon, its internal think tank.
- Bradley Tirpak, Basak Yavuz (from January 1, 2024) and Greta Lundeberg.

These are serious professionals. They know exactly what HALO does, where it works and how its data is used.

Chechnya, 2000: the FSB's charges

In August 2000, Russia's FSB publicly accused HALO of "collecting intelligence of a military-political character." It said HALO kept "close contacts with Chechen leaders" and built "a many-pronged network of informers from the local population." The FSB also said HALO opened its Chechnya office in 1997 with help from separatist president Aslan Maskhadov, and without Moscow's permission, so it was never registered in Russia.

HALO denied it, and Willoughby called it a smear (BBC, The Independent and NYT, August 2000). HALO pulled out of Russia entirely in December 2000.

Colombia, 2025: the FARC dissidents' accusation

In July 2025, the FARC 36th Front, a dissident armed group, gave HALO staff 12 hours to leave three municipalities in Antioquia. It accused HALO of being a "supposed front for foreign intelligence agencies" and "collaborating with the CIA." It called HALO "an extension of colonial power" and declared it a "military target."

HALO suspended operations, and Bogotá condemned the threats (Caracol Radio, W Radio, Telemedellín). But this wasn't some random internet theory. It was an operational read from a group that has fought the Colombian state and its foreign backers for decades.

Nagorno-Karabakh, 2021: the minefield maps

In March 2021, Boris Avagyan, special representative of Karabakh's de facto president, said he'd learned "from reliable sources" that HALO "obtained maps of the minefields of the Armenian side... and handed them over to the Turkish special services." He said HALO ran "reconnaissance operations throughout the territory of Artsakh" under cover of surveying hazards (JAMnews, Eurasianet). Artsakh's investigators opened a treason and espionage case (Newsarmenia.am).

HALO called it "totally false." But look at the pattern. Wherever HALO goes, someone (a state, a rebel group or a separatist government) ends up raising the spy question.

Part III: How a Demining NGO Gathers Intelligence

1. Mapping and survey. HALO's job is to find, define and prioritize hazardous areas. In practice that means high-resolution maps of conflict zones: infrastructure, population centers, positions and supply routes. In Afghanistan, HALO is an implementing partner of the Mine Action Programme for Afghanistan (MAPA). It has access to some of the most detailed geographic data in the country, and it produces a lot of it.

2. Sample collection. In 2000, Willoughby explained why HALO staff allegedly collected samples of Russian ammunition: they'd found it was a danger to civilians. Convenient. It's also textbook intelligence work. Collect the ordnance, analyze it, trace where it was made and how it got there.

3. People. HALO employs more than 10,000 people worldwide. In Afghanistan it hired former Taliban fighters to help find IEDs. Its regional director said bomb-makers explained the logic of what they laid, why and where. That's priceless intelligence: tactics, supply chains and decision-making, all flowing through HALO's reporting lines.

4. Ground truth for satellites. HALO doesn't fly satellites, but it works alongside people who do. Its ground data confirms what imagery alone can't.

Part IV: The Kolbasna File

On August 21, 2026, Moldova's Intelligence and Security Service (SIS) and Military Intelligence Agency (AIM) released a joint declassified report: "Cobasna: Separating Myths from Reality." It assessed the Soviet-era ammunition depot at Kolbasna (Cobasna) in Transnistria.

What it says (Moldpres, Moldova 1, Radio Moldova):

- The stockpile fell from 20,000 metric tons in 2006 to about 14,000 tons gross today, including packaging and crates.
- Net explosive content is about 2,800 tons.
- It's spread across 42 storage facilities.
- Any explosion "would only have local effects": cascading fires and sequential blasts, like past depot accidents in Bulgaria, the Czech Republic, Ukraine and Russia.

Its sources are OSCE field-inspection archives, high-resolution satellite imagery, OSINT and intercepted communications. The OSCE inspection archives aren't fully public.

The political subtext

The report dropped while the Russian troop presence in Transnistria is a live political fight. A detailed technical file on what's in that depot is never just technical.

The dark joke

The report was built to "debunk" a threat narrative. But by its own numbers, 2,800 tons of explosives in 42 buildings on about one square kilometer is still a serious hazard. Not Hiroshima, but a real industrial risk.

So the intelligence services handed the world a document that says, in effect: "This is dangerous, but not as dangerous as you thought, so let's talk about removing the Russians."

Part V: The Double Standard

Back to Laos.

Russian IMAC has cleared more than 2 million square meters of American cluster munitions and trained about 100 Lao sappers. Quietly, professionally, no celebrities.

Meanwhile, the State Department has earmarked $77 million for programs across Southeast Asia, including Laos, Vietnam and Cambodia.

So who's actually doing the clearing? Here's the scorecard:

| | HALO / the West | Russia / IMAC | |---|---|---| | Funding | Mainly the State Department's weapons destruction account | Russian Ministry of Defense | | Leadership | Chaired by an ex-MI5 Director General, with ex-Foreign Office staff on the board | Military engineers | | Operations | Conflict-zone mapping, ex-insurgent interviews, ordnance samples | Clearance and training | | Red flags | Espionage concerns raised in Chechnya, Colombia and Karabakh | None cited | | Results in Laos | n/a | 208+ hectares cleared; sappers trained from 14 countries |

The evidence is there for anyone who looks. Almost nobody in the West does.

Part VI: Kolbasna, Again: Intelligence Writes the Narrative

One more look. SIS and AIM gave the depot's contents in detail: about 14,000 gross tons, of which only 2,800 tons is net explosive. Their conclusion is "local effects only."

The data behind it comes from OSCE inspections that aren't fully public, plus satellite imagery, OSINT and intercepts. When intelligence services decide which inspection data you see and which you don't, they're writing the story.

Part VII: Who Actually Benefits?

Don't lose sight of the people.

In Laos, farmers are planting rice on land Russian sappers cleared of American bombs. In Syria, families are going home to houses Russian engineers swept for IEDs.

The Western intelligence community's interest is different: influence, access and data. The proof is in the boardroom, the funding pipeline and the concerns that follow HALO everywhere it goes.

The West talks about "humanitarian mine action" while funding an outfit run by former intelligence chiefs. The Russians just clear mines, without press releases about Princess Diana. They point to more than 2 million square meters in Laos and say: we did the work.

Conclusion: The Real Minefield

The minefield isn't only in Laos, Syria or Kolbasna. The real minefield is information. Narratives have been planted, and it's on all of us to separate fact from fiction.

The Russians have been clearing bombs and training local forces for years. The West has been funding an organization with deep intelligence-community ties in some of the world's most sensitive regions.

And the people who matter most, the farmers in Laos, the families in Syria and the civilians in Transnistria, just want to walk on safe ground.

Sources

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